

DELHI SEEMS TO be in a state of anticipation. Renovation work is being carried out at a frenetic pace across the city—roads and pavements are being repaired, LED lights are being installed, gardens, fountains and sculptures are being put up at prominent traffic islands and a state-of-the-art international exhibition-cum-convention centre has been built at Pragati Maidan at a cost of ₹2,700 crore. The centre, inaugurated by Prime

Minister Narendra Modi on July 26, will host world leaders such as US President Joe Biden and British Prime Minister Rishi Sunak at the G20 Leaders' Summit on September 9-10. The event will mark the culmination of India's year-long presidency of the G20.

The beautification of the capital may seem superfluous, but the bigger tangible gain for India this year has been the ability to showcase itself as an emerging economic superpower, with recent data and reports hailing it as a force to reckon with.

For instance, Morgan Stanley has upgraded India to 'overweight' and strategists at the brokerage believe that India is at the start of a "long wave boom" even as China may be ending one. S&P Global expects India to grow 6.7 per cent per year from FY24 to FY31, catapulting GDP to \$6.7 trillion from \$3.4 trillion in FY23.

And India seems to be combining this growing economic clout with its G20 presidency to make its tryst with history as it takes up difficult and urgent issues that require global attention. Countries across the world are trying to repair the damage from the twin shocks of the Covid-19 pandemic and the Russia-Ukraine war and move to a new normal of slower growth, higher inflation, widening socioeconomic disparities and extreme weather-related events.

"We are at a very interesting time. India has done exceptionally well and in doing exceptionally well, there are certain learnings India can share with the world and that is elevating India's presidency to a new level," veteran banker K.V. Kamath, Chairman of the National Bank for Financing Infrastructure and Development (NaBFID), tells *Business Today*. (To read his column, turn to page 84.)

He points out that during the Covid-19 crisis that led to problems in the financial sector, and then amid the problems in Europe, India is one economy that quickly tackled these challenges and returned to normalcy without imposing significant pain on the system.

SETTING THE AGENDA

India's priorities at the discussion table

- REFORM OF MULTILATERAL DEVELOPMENT BANKS TO MAKE THEM MORE RELEVANT FOR THE GLOBAL SOUTH
- A GLOBAL FRAMEWORK TO REGULATE CRYPTOCURRENCIES AND CRYPTO ASSETS
- SPEEDIER RESOLUTION OF DEBT STRESS FACED BY SEVERAL COUNTRIES
- DEVELOPING DIGITAL PUBLIC INFRASTRUCTURE TO HELP IMPROVE DEVELOPMENT OUTCOMES ACROSS NATIONS
- INCLUSION OF THE AFRICAN UNION AS A FULL MEMBER OF THE G20
- ACCELERATING SUSTAINABLE DEVELOPMENT GOALS AND SUSTAINABLE LIFESTYLE THROUGH LIFE

AN AGENDA FOR DEVELOPMENT

But what is so special about the G20 presidency, given that it is a rotating one? The importance of this grouping lies in the very fact that it consists of the 20 most powerful economies in the world, which got together for the first time in 1999 after the East Asian financial crisis to discuss global economic and financial issues.

Over the years, its mandate has expanded to take up all possible issues in the world such as climate change and energy, says Suresh Prabhu, former Union Minister and former Sherpa for India to the G20 and G7. "As of today, G20 constitutes more than 80 per cent of the global GDP. So, these are the most important countries in the world in terms of output," he says. While economic issues will be the most important, every host country has the prerogative to take up any priority issue at the G20 forum, says Prabhu, a veteran of these talks.

